

3. *Thomas Dease / Tomás Déis*

It is clear, therefore, that throughout most of the history of the Irish collegiate community in Paris there was not merely widespread knowledge of Irish but also awareness of its vocational, cultural and intellectual significance. This familiarity is already epitomized in the person of Thomas Dease,¹ who was appointed superior of the Irish College in succession to John Lee in 1621, having been summoned to Paris by Lee to continue the work which he himself could no longer carry on because of his advanced years. Dease was born in 1568 at Turbotstown in County Westmeath to a family of landed gentry, and his nephew Richard continued in possession of the family property at the time of the rising in 1641. Through his mother, Lady Eleanor Nugent, he was related to the Nugents of Delvin and to many other of the noble families of the Pale.² He spent some time in the Irish College at Douai before going to Paris where he received his M.A. from the University there

¹ The family surname is variously written Dease, Deaze, Deece, Deize, Déis, Deis, Desse, and Deys(e).

² D. F. Cregan, 'The social and cultural background of a counter-reformation episcopate, 1618-60', in *Studies in Irish History presented to R. Dudley Edwards* (A. Cosgrove and D. McCartney (ed.), Dublin 1979) 85-117 (95).

in 1601 and his Licence in Theology in 1612, about which time he himself taught as a Professor of Theology at Collège de Navarre.¹ Nominated bishop of Meath in 1621, he was consecrated in 1622 and held that office until his death, in Galway, in 1652.

He had a reputation for learning: he was, says Dr John Lynch, highly skilled in the Irish language and in other sciences (*Hibernicae linguae, sicut aliarum etiam scientiarum, peritissimimus fuit*). All the evidence suggests he was diligent and judicious in maintaining good order in the churches of his diocese, and Lynch speaks of the joyful serenity of his expression and the happy good humour that charmed his acquaintances.²

Yet in the last decade of his life circumstances conspired to set him at odds with many of his peers within and without the Church. The Ulster insurrection of 1641, energized by the return of Eoghan Rua Ó Néill from Spain in the following year, spread to other areas throughout the country, and gathered in support from the 'Old English', the lords and gentry of the Pale with whom Thomas Dease had so many ties of kinship and association. When at the instigation of the Catholic hierarchy a provisional parliament or General Assembly was set up, otherwise known as the Confederation of Kilkenny, it brought together the native Irish and the Old English in an alliance rooted in their common religion and in the common fear that if the puritan and parliamentary faction were to win out in England they would all, Irish and Old English alike, share the same fate as recusants. However, it

¹He is included in a list of priests who had been students at Douai in a letter addressed by the President of the college to the Archduke and Archduchess of Austria in 1613 (*Calendar of the Carew Manuscripts* (London 1873) 286).

²Lynch, *De Praesulibus Hiberniae* (ed. J. F. O'Doherty, Dublin 1944), I, 169.

was an insecure alliance, lacking the bond of a firm common purpose; the Old English, having less to gain through victory and more to lose in defeat, were more amenable to a tolerable compromise than either the expropriated Irish or the Catholic hierarchy. Cohesive action fell prey to conflicting aims and interests and, when the earl of Ormond, who was charged by king Charles with the responsibility of securing the defence of Dublin and the government, initiated negotiations for a cessation of war, the underlying faults in the unity of the Confederation widened into factional oppositions. While the lords of the Pale favoured acceptance of Ormond's limited concessions, the Irish and the Catholic clergy, strongly supported by the new Papal Nuncio, Giovanni Battista Rinuccini, were united in rejecting them. In the end Irish hopes of an equitable settlement were frustrated and the decisive riposte of a troubled English state came in August 1649 when Oliver Cromwell landed in Dublin as civil and military Governor of Ireland.

The personal significance of these fateful times for Thomas Dease was that he found himself broadly in sympathy in matters of policy with his Old English friends and relatives and therefore at variance with the views of most of his fellow bishops and clerics, not to speak of the Papal Nuncio; he may also have believed, as argued by John Lynch, that the Irish lacked the resources and experience to win the war.¹ On assuming control of his bishopric in 1642 he called upon a synod of his clergy to cooperate with him in reforming prevalent abuses and warned them of the need to prove themselves loyal subjects to the English government in all things compatible with conscience: 'Unqualified loyalty was the fixed and ruling principle of his life, and nothing would

¹ Lynch, *De Praesulibus* 169.

have been more paradoxical in his eyes than an attempt to subvert any government, no matter how despotic or unjust.¹ He absented himself from a synod of the bishops of the province of Ulster held at Kells in March 1642 and presided over by Dr Hugh O'Reilly, Archbishop of Armagh, where it was declared that the war entered into by the Catholics of Ireland was just and lawful, and it was he, apparently, who prevailed upon his maternal relative Richard Nugent, tenth Baron of Delvin (whose home he resided in from 1622 to 1642) not to join with his fellow gentry in the campaign of insurrection. Clearly there was a wide gulf between the primate and the bishop's perceptions of the Church's role in the contemporary political situation, a difference that cannot have been eased by their awareness that Hugh O'Reilly's father and uncles had lost their lands in east Breifne to the Nugent family of Westmeath who were both friends and relatives of Dease.²

Seven years later, on 17 July 1649, when a peace treaty was finally agreed with Ormond in the last phase of the Confederate campaign, Dease was one of nine bishops who appended their signatures.³ Diocesan historian Fr Anthony Cogan pays due tribute to the sincerity of his motives:

¹ C. P. Meehan, *The rise and fall of the Irish Franciscan monasteries and memoirs of the Irish hierarchy in the seventeenth century* (Dublin 1872) 165.

² This has been adverted to by S. P. Ó Mórdha, 'Hugh O'Reilly (1581?-1653): a reforming prelate', *Breifne* 4 (1970-75) 1-42, 345-69 (11). According to John Lynch (*De Praesulibus* 142) O'Reilly studied philosophy at Rouen, where Lynch saw him as a young student, and subsequently theology at Paris, but there does not appear to be any evidence that he was attached to the Irish College in Paris (J. O'Boyle, *The Irish colleges on the continent* (Dublin 1935) 206).

³ A. Cogan, *The Diocese of Meath, ancient and modern* (Dublin [1867] repr. 1992) II, 39-40, 56; J. T. Gilbert (ed.), *A contemporary history of affairs in Ireland from 1641 to 1652* (Dublin 1879-80) I, 34-6.

When the war broke out, in 1641, he was then an old man. He was opposed to the 'rising' as premature, and he took no part in the Synod of Kells, because, in all likelihood, he feared there was no probability of success. When the prelates declared the war to be 'just and meritorious', he joined the Confederation, and, in course of time, became a member of the Supreme Council. Although he took no active part in its proceedings, his nephew, Oliver Dease, who was vicar-general of the diocese, attended the deliberations, and hence may be regarded as his representative. At the Synod of Waterford in 1646, Oliver Dease assisted as V.G. of Meath, and signed the condemnation of the peace with Ormond, with the concurrence, it may be presumed, of his uncle ...

Dr Dease's politics were diametrically opposed to those of the Nuncio. He seems to have been lukewarm in the cause of the Confederation, and whenever he took any conspicuous part in the councils of the Confederates, it was to oppose and resist the policy of Rinuccini.¹

¹ Cogan, *The Diocese of Meath* II, 52-3. Cogan's near-contemporary Fr C. P. Meehan is equally fair and balanced in his treatment of Dease, though he cannot forgo the occasional discreet reminder of the inherited loyalties which informed his conduct, as for example: 'The interests of the prelate and the baron [Richard Baron of Delvin] were in most respects identical, for both were zealous sons of holy Church, and both were in the peaceful enjoyment of a large estate. Religion counselled obedience to higher powers, and prudence suggested that neither of them ought to compromise a fair inheritance by manifesting discontent or sympathy with 'the dispossessed,' whose main object was to recover their forfeited lands' (*The Irish Franciscan Monasteries* 166).

However, in the heat of the struggle the Papal Nuncio found it more difficult to muster up such expressions of sympathy and understanding. When a report reached Rinuccini on 4 July 1648 that Bishop Dease, then extremely ill, had died, he wrote to Rome:

The Bishop of Meath is dead, at the age of eighty, to the great gain of this kingdom; for he was a man of almost heretical sentiments, and I have been obliged to threaten to send him to Rome, even at his advanced age, ...

And when the report proved premature and the patient recovered, the Nuncio sent a further message:

The Bishop of Meath is not dead, but has been spared to try the patience of the good.¹

Rinuccini's strictures almost pale by comparison with the comments of another contemporary of Bishop Dease: the anonymous author of the tract entitled *An aphorismical discovery of treasonable faction*, thought to have been written between 1652 and 1660, a composition teeming with precious insights and unbridled prejudices. A committed royalist whose admiration of Eoghan Rua Ó Néill was matched by his abhorrence of the Puritans and the 'Treasonable Faction' comprising Ormond and other nobles of the Pale, our author rails against these incessantly in passionate and colourful language, and he is hardly less restrained in dealing with those Catholic prelates and clergy — among them Thomas Dease — whom he represents as allying themselves with the 'faction'. His pen picture of Dease is a characteristic example of his vivid style:

¹Cogan, *The Diocese of Meath* II, 56; Meehan, *Irish Franciscan monasteries*, 171.

As for Thomas Deaz, Bishope of Meathe, he is a man that euer yett spent his time in jolitie, composinge of Irish reemes, more like libells than any exemplarie or vertuos myters (as the subiecte now offered), displayinge therin the secret faults or privat miscariadge of either sex, whether right or wronge, to the noe smale discreditt of noble personages of both encumbencie and extraction, was euer yett auerse unto the holy warr of this, an ill affected member unto the chiefe promoters and best seruitors of both kinge and kingdome, bearinge an inueterat hatred and malice unto the ancient Irish, disobedient to both Nuncio, provincially and nationall congregations, wherby existed seuerally and nominatim excommunicated, and caused all his priests to run the same scene of disobedience, and his Vicar Generall, his owne nephewe Oliuer Deaz. . . . All the rest that signed to the said queres, were of noe better qualitie or stuffe, then the formentioned. Judge then, indifferent reader, what credence should any man of understandinge giue this booke, calified and aproved by such authors? Sure it had been a disgrace to any man of repute (though the subiecte were aliâs reasonable, and by his superiors admittance) to signe unto it, in company of such a rable of men, the scum and froath of religions, in all the kingdome.¹

That the writer took a jaundiced view of Thomas Dease is something of an understatement, but he does advert — though in a spirit of sarcasm — to a feature of the bishop's

¹J. T. Gilbert, *A contemporary history* I, 278–9 (see n.30).

life and personality which receives little notice elsewhere. That he was a poet we know from other sources: already in the seventeenth century John Lynch mentions the various verse compositions in Irish he crafted at night by candle-light and which were enjoyed for their charm and style.¹ Four of his poems and a separate quatrain in loose syllabic metre have survived and been published by modern editors. Two of them have a common theme: the transience of women's beauty. The first of them, beginning *Gabh mo theagasc, a inghean óg* 'Listen to my counsel, young girl', entreats the young woman to remember that the attributes of which she is now so proud — her lips, her shining teeth, her languorous eye and her thick golden hair — must end in the dissolution of the grave, and to think instead of hell and repentance. In the three quatrains of the second poem, *A dhuine ó ndeachaidh do bhean* 'O man whose wife has departed', the advice is addressed to the male, but remains essentially the same: not to be seduced by woman's physical charms, which are so short-lived.² The other two poems dwell on the topos of contemporary social and moral decadence. One of them, *Mór sochair na h-aimsire* 'Great are the benefits of our time', focuses primarily on the decline of the clergy from the piety and learning of earlier times:

*Níl saor ná sodaire,
gion go léigheann a phaidear,
san diadhacht nach iúlmhaire
a-nois ná Pádraig is Peadar*

*Scriptúir Dé níor thuigeadar
Augustín, Greaghóir ná Béda,*

¹ Lynch, *De Praesulibus* 169–70.

² T. Ua Brádaigh (ed.), 'Dhá dhán le Tomás Déis, easbog na Mí', *Ríocht na Midhe* 3 (1963–6) 99–104.

's cách uile do shluigeadar
a-nois ó cuireadh i mBéarla

'There is not a tradesman or clodhopper, even though he does not read his Pater Noster, who is not now more knowledgeable in theology than St Patrick or St Peter. Neither Augustine nor Gregory nor Bede understood God's scripture, while everyone else has swallowed it now that it has been turned into English'.

The other poem, *Rinneas mo thiomna, a Shéamuis* 'Seamus, I have made my testament', takes a wider view of the fall from the older standards of nobility, prosperity and liberality in Irish society as a whole, and briefly echoes the frequent lament of the professional poets of the time for the loss of their traditional patrons: *D'fhágghas filidh ar fággháil, gan tárrtháil fán ngréin aca* 'I left the poets bereft, with no refuge under the sun'.¹

The aphoristic quatrain which is frequently attributed to Dease in manuscript copies has a note of resigned disillusion which would not have been inappropriate to the last phase of his long life:

*As mórdheimhniughadh na gcompánach
is tearc a bhfagháil dílis;
tar éis trágha gach tobair
is annsin haithnithear an fíoruisce*

'For all the assurances of friends
rarely do they remain constant;

¹É. Ó Tuathail (ed.), *An t-Ulltach* 29, no. 8 (August 1953) 11–12; 31, no. 7 (July 1955) 5–6; no. 8, (August 1953) 6.

when all other wells have run dry,
it is then is revealed the true spring'¹

Politically Bishop Dease may have been oriented toward the gentry of the Pale and the English connection, but culturally his attachment was to the literary and ideological world mediated through the Irish language. It was a characteristically 'marcher' duality and one he shared with some of his kinsmen the Nugents who, despite the colonial cast of their politics, were known and praised as patrons of the *filidh*, the professional poets, and particularly of the Ó Cobhthaighs of the Westmeath area. There is a vellum manuscript in the National Library of Ireland which is known as *An duanaire Nuinseannach* 'the poem-book of the Nugents' and is dated by a colophon to the year 1577: *Anno domini 1577 7 an ix-madh bliadhain .x. do quuiin Isibél a rígeacht hShaxan 7 Éireann* 'the year of the Lord 1577 and the nineteenth year of Queen Elizabeth's being ruler of England and Ireland.' In its extant state — some leaves appear to have been lost — the manuscript contains forty-nine poems of which eighteen are ascribed to Ó Cobhthaigh poets.² One of them composed an elegy on Richard Nugent, the eighth baron of Delvin, who died in 1559. Another, Muircheartach Ó Cobhthaigh, composed a poem in praise of Richard's son Christopher,

¹Printed in Ua Brádaigh, 'Dhá dhán' 101.

²B. Ó Cuív describes the manuscript in his R. I. Best Memorial Lecture *The Irish bardic duanaire* (Dublin 1973) 11–14. See also the introductory comments by D. Ó Cróinín to his edition from MS G 992 of a poem to Toirdhealbhaich Luineach Ó Néill composed by Muircheartach Ó Cobhthaigh (*Éigse* 16 (1975–6) 50–66 (55)); he suggests that this poem may have been composed in connection with a gathering of the poets of Ireland hosted by Toirdhealbhaich Luineach at Christmas 1577, which also sets the theme for Tadhg Dall Ó hUiginn's poem 'Nollaig do-chuamar don Chraoibh' in E. Knott (ed.), *The Bardic Poems of Tadhg Dall Ó Huiginn* (London 1922, 1926) I, 50–6, II, 34–7, 222.

in which he urged that he be raised to the rank of earl; it was this Christopher who found favour with Queen Elizabeth while a student at Cambridge and who prepared a short primer of the Irish language for her.¹ Another son of Richard's, William (Uilliam Nuinseann), was himself an accomplished poet in Irish, one of whose compositions, a poem of exile, *Diombáidh triall ó thulchaibh Fáil* 'It is sad to go from the hills of Ireland', is familiar to all readers of classical Irish verse. William was a close friend of the well-known poet Giolla Brighde (Bonaventura) Ó hEodhusa, who entered the Franciscan order in 1607 at the College of St Anthony in Louvain, and we have a poem addressed to him from the Netherlands by Giolla Brighde expressing the sadness of their separation — 'the crown of all grief is that I have lost William Nugent's gay spirit' (*Barr ar gach teidhm mar tá sinn / d'éis meanman Uilliam Nuinnsinn*) — and another to his wife Janet, daughter of Walter Marward of Skreen in Co. Meath on the death of her son Richard.²

There was yet another poet of the Nugents, known in Irish as Séamus Dubh Nuinnsionn, of whom little is known except that he seems to have lived in the barony of Delvin. With him we return directly to Thomas Dease, for the two

¹ Aspects of Christopher's career, and that of other members of the Nugent family, are discussed in Basil Iske, *The green cockatrice* (Tara, Co. Meath 1987).

² É. Ó Tuathail, 'Nugentiana', *Éigse* 2 (1940) 4–14; G. Murphy, 'Poems of exile by Uilliam mac Barúin Dealbhna', *Éigse* 6 (1949) 8–15; T. Ua Brádaigh, 'Na Nuinnsionnaigh, mór-theaghlach Gall-Ghaelach, agus an cultúr Gaelach', *Ríocht na Midhe* 3 (1963–66) 211–21; B. Ó Buachalla, 'Diombáidh triall ó thulchaibh Fáil', in *Nua-Dhuanairé : cuid I* (ed. P. de Brún et al. Dublin 1971) 6, 179. For an edition and translation of the two poems by Giolla Brighde Ó hEodhusa see O. Bergin, *Irish bardic poetry: texts and translations* (ed. D. Greene and F. Kelly, Dublin 1970) 139–45, 276–79; C. Mháig Craith (ed.), *Dán na mBráthar Mionúr I* (Dublin 1967) 31–8, II (Dublin 1980) 13–16, 119–26.

were evidently good friends who sometimes exchanged greetings in verse, and it may be presumed that this was the friend addressed in the opening line of the bishop's own poem, *Rinneas mo thiomna, a Shéamuis*.¹

What remains of Bishop Dease's verse is modest in volume but marked by good wit and an easy, controlled style. As it stands, it would seem much further removed from the disreputable 'reemes, more like libells' his choleric critic of the *Aphorismical discovery* charges him with than from the 'exemplarie or vertuos myters' from which he dissociates him. But on the whole manuscript tradition tends to favour the formal over the ephemeral, and it may well be that there was another, more relaxed dimension to Dease's versifying, for example in the occasional verse correspondence he seems to have carried on with Séamus Dubh Nuinnsionn. After all, John Lynch's thumb-nail sketch suggests a man of spirit and good humour, and indeed of 'jolitie'.

¹For Séamus Dubh Nuinnsionn see T. Ua Brádaigh, 'Na Nuinnseonaigh', *Ríocht na Midhe* 3 (1963-6) 211-21 (219-21).